

PANGOLINS

With a body covered in large keratin scales, pangolins are also known as scaly anteaters, reflecting their appearance and diet.

Mainly nocturnal and with small eyes, pangolins use their excellent sense of smell to find food. Although somewhat similar in appearance to the American armadillos, and sharing a similar diet, pangolins belong to a different order, Pholidota, and are most closely related to the carnivores.

The horny scales, which cover all exposed parts of the body, can make up one fifth of a pangolin's body weight: despite this, they are excellent swimmers. There are both terrestrial and arboreal species: ground-dwellers live in deep burrows, while tree-dwellers live in holes in trees.

Pangolins have powerful claws that are used to excavate insect nests. Food is captured on the sticky tongue, which extends up to 40 cm (16 in) from the toothless mouth. Because of the size of their front claws, pangolins walk on their wrists, the forepaws curled over to protect the claws.

SAFE FROM ATTACK

The role of the scaly coat is as protection against predators, enhanced by the tendency of pangolins to roll into a ball when threatened or sleeping. Further defence is provided by their ability to emit a foul-smelling chemical from their anal glands, which is also used to mark territory. Nevertheless, pangolins are heavily exploited for their meat, scales, and perceived value in traditional Chinese medicine.

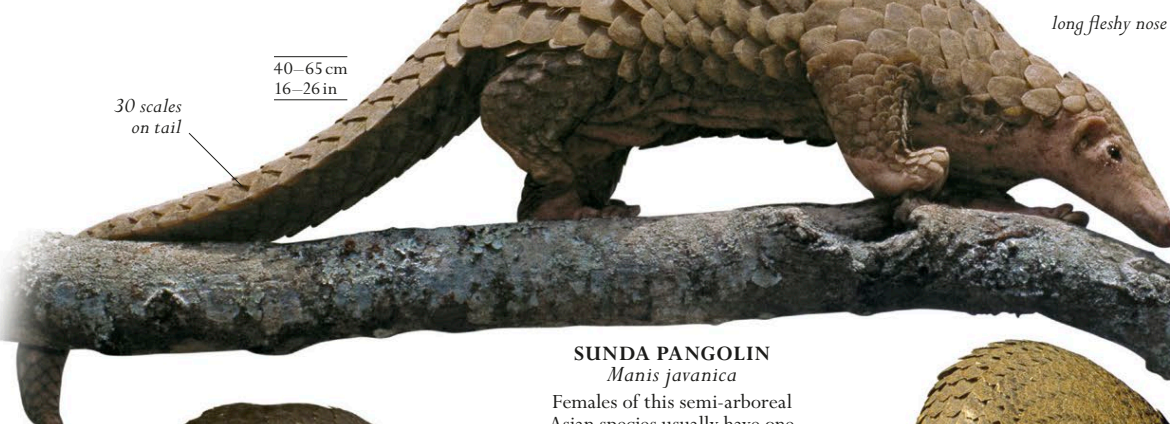
PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	PHOLIDOTA
FAMILIES	1
SPECIES	8



The long, sticky tongue of this African ground-dwelling pangolin is used for drinking as well as capturing insects.

MANIDAE

The eight pangolin species of the family Manidae live in tropical Africa and Asia. They are unique among mammals in having their skin protected by large horny scales. When threatened, they can curl up into a ball, the sharp plate edges providing additional defence. Large, powerful front claws are used to excavate ant hills and termite mounds in search of food, captured by sticky saliva on their long, probing tongue.



SUNDA PANGOLIN

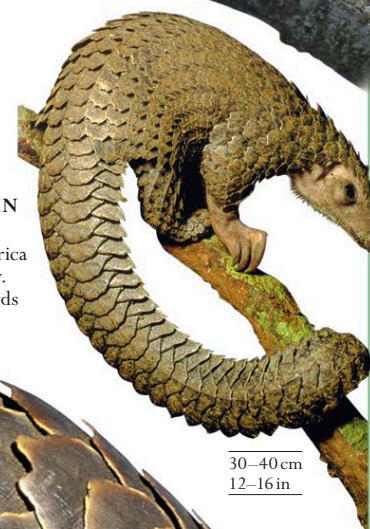
Manis javanica

Females of this semi-arboreal Asian species usually have one offspring, which is carried on the tail when a few days old.

LONG-TAILED PANGOLIN

Manis tetradactyla

This small pangolin from W. Africa lives high in the forest canopy. It has a prehensile tail two-thirds of its total body length.



AFRICAN TREE PANGOLIN

Manis tricuspis

This arboreal pangolin from equatorial Africa has pale fur and distinctive three-pointed scales, although the points can become worn with age.



51–75 cm
20–30 in

INDIAN PANGOLIN

Manis crassicaudata

Its overlapping scales and ability to emit a noxious defensive fluid can protect this pangolin even from the attentions of tigers.

broad, rounded scales

GROUND PANGOLIN

Manis temminckii

The only pangolin in southern and eastern Africa, this species is very secretive. It is nocturnal and walks on four feet, or two if foraging for food.

45–55 cm
18–22 in

